

Moving to Japan: A Step-by-Step Guide

We've broken down the relocation process into manageable steps to guide you through your journey to Japan.

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BEFORE YOU ARRIVE IN JAPAN

1. Get a Visa

To move to Japan, you'll need a visa — the most common are a **Work Visa** (requires a job offer) or the new **Digital Nomad Visa** (for remote workers from select countries). Other common visas include a dependent/spouse visa and a student visa. If you're job hunting, check out:

- [\[GaijinPot\]](#)
- [\[Jobs in Japan\]](#)
- [\[Boston Career Forum\]](#)
- [\[JET Programme\]](#)



Once you've got your **Certificate of Eligibility**, apply for your visa through your local Japanese embassy. **Apply at least 1.5 months before departure** from your home country, not while in Japan.

2. Set Up Your Japanese Name

Create your **katakana name** — it'll be used in forms and legal docs. Try this [name converter tool](link to name converter tool).

3. Do Preparations in Your Home Country

Finances:

- Get **international ATM access**. Contact your bank to understand fees and enable international use.
- Apply for a **travel-friendly credit card** with no or low foreign transaction fees.
- For **money transfers**, consider using [\[Wise\]](#) or [\[OFX\]](#) for potentially better exchange rates and lower fees.

Driving:

- Apply for an [\[International Driving Permit\]](#) in your home country. Note that this is usually valid for one year after your arrival in Japan.

Medication:

- **Check if your medications are legal in Japan**. Some common medications in other countries are restricted or require special permission.
- Bring **printed prescriptions** from your doctor, including the generic names of the medications.
- Consider bringing an adequate supply until you can find a local doctor if needed.

Electronics:

- Japan uses **Type A/B plugs** and a **100V voltage**. You may need adapters and possibly voltage converters for some devices.

4. Find Housing

You'll need at least temporary housing to get a phone number and bank account.

Long-term rental listings:

- [\[At Home\]](#)
- [\[Suumo\]](#)
- [\[GaijinPot Apartments\]](#)

Short-term/foreigner-friendly housing:

- **Monthly rentals:** [\[At Inn\]](#)
- **Sharehouses:** [\[Sakura House\]](#) / [\[Oak House\]](#)

Note: Some rentals don't accept foreigners or pets and may require a guarantor. Use Google Chrome to translate the websites into your native language. It's also common to pay key money (礼金 - *reikin*) and a security deposit.

WHEN YOU ARRIVE IN JAPAN

5. Complete Legal Registration

- Get your **residence card** (在留カード - *zairyū kādo*) at the airport upon arrival.
- **Register your address at your local ward office within 14 days** of finding accommodation. You'll need your residence card.
- **Enroll in National Health Insurance** (国民健康保険 - *kokumin kenkō hoken*) at the ward office. It covers 70% of medical costs.

6. Get a Phone Number

You'll need a Japanese phone number to open a bank account or sign a lease.

Friendly SIM providers:

- [\[Sakura Mobile\]](#)
- [\[Mobal\]](#)
- [\[IJJmio\]](#)

Bring your **passport** and **residence card**. Consider whether you need a voice plan or just data.

7. Get a Bank Account

Required for receiving salary, signing leases, and setting up utilities.

Foreigner-friendly banks:

- [\[SMBC Prestia\]](#)
- [\[Shinsei Bank\]](#)

These banks are known to offer more English customer support and understanding of expats' needs/concerns. Bring your **passport**, **residence card**, **Japanese phone number**, and **proof of address** (e.g., a utility bill or official letter with your registered address).

8. Get a Credit Card

Recommended cards for newcomers:

- [\[Rakuten Card\]](#)
- [\[EPOS Card\]](#)

Japanese credit card applications can be harder to pass for expats initially. These cards are often easier to attain and offer good benefits. Bring your **residence card, phone number, and income information** (if applicable).

9. Set Up Your Utilities

You'll need a **Japanese bank account and phone number** to set up internet, gas, water, and electricity.

Utility providers often offer online forms — have your **move-in date and address ready**. You might need to contact them to schedule a connection.

10. Apply for Essentials

- **MyNumber card** (マイナンバーカード - *mai nanbā kārdo*) (**national ID**): Apply after address registration at your local ward office. [\[More info\]](#)
- **National Pension** (国民年金 - *kokumin nenkin*): Visit your local ward office to enroll or inquire about potential exemptions based on your visa status.
- **Local Clinics & Schools**: Use [\[Tokyo's English-friendly clinic directory\]](#). Also check [\[r/japanlife\]](#) for expat advice and recommendations.
- **Popular Japanese Apps**:
 - **LINE** – Main messaging app: [\[Download \(iOS\)\]](#) / [\[Download \(Android\)\]](#)
 - **PayPay** – Mobile payments: [\[Download \(iOS\)\]](#) / [\[Download \(Android\)\]](#)
 - **Suica** (iOS): [\[Download\]](#)
 - **PASMO** (Android): [\[Download\]](#)
 - **Google Translate** – Menu/sign translation: [\[Download \(iOS\)\]](#) / [\[Download \(Android\)\]](#)
 - **Mercari** – Secondhand goods marketplace: [\[Download \(iOS\)\]](#) / [\[Download \(Android\)\]](#)